

Microsoft Copilot is a generative artificial intelligence chatbot developed by Microsoft AI, a division of Microsoft. Based on the Microsoft Prometheus large language model, it was launched in 2023 as Microsoft's main replacement for the discontinued Cortana.

The service was introduced in February 2023 under the name Bing Chat, as a built-in feature for Microsoft Bing and Microsoft Edge but would later be integrated into Windows and Microsoft 365 under various names. Over the course of 2023, Microsoft began to unify the Copilot branding across its various chatbot products, cementing the "copilot" analogy.

Microsoft introduced the Microsoft 365 Copilot app in January 2025, which was a rebranded version of the Microsoft 365 app. The app works differently than the consumer version of Copilot, being centred more on work, business and education users.

Copilot utilizes the Microsoft Prometheus model, built upon OpenAI's GPT large language models, which in turn have been fine-tuned using both supervised and reinforcement learning techniques. Copilot's conversational interface style resembles that of ChatGPT. The chatbot is able to cite sources, create poems, generate songs, and use numerous languages and dialects.

Microsoft operates Copilot on a freemium model. Users on its free tier can access most features, while priority access to newer features, including custom chatbot creation, is provided to paid subscribers under paid subscription services. Several default chatbots are available in the free version of Microsoft Copilot, including the standard Copilot chatbot as well as Microsoft Designer, which is oriented towards using its Image Creator to generate images based on text prompts.

Background

In 2019, Microsoft partnered with OpenAI and began investing billions of dollars into the organization. Since then, OpenAI systems have run on an Azure-based supercomputing platform from Microsoft. In September 2020, Microsoft announced that it had licensed

OpenAI's GPT-3 exclusively. Others can still receive output from its public API, but Microsoft has exclusive access to the underlying model.

In November 2022, OpenAI launched ChatGPT, a chatbot which was based on GPT-3.5. ChatGPT gained worldwide attention following its release, becoming a viral Internet sensation. On January 23, 2023, Microsoft announced a multi-year US\$10 billion investment in OpenAI. On February 6, Google announced Bard (later rebranded as Gemini), a ChatGPT-like chatbot service, fearing that ChatGPT could threaten Google's place as a go-to source for information. Multiple media outlets and financial analysts described Google as "rushing" Bard's announcement to preempt rival Microsoft's planned February 7 event unveiling Copilot, as well as to avoid playing "catch-up" to Microsoft.

The terms of service of Copilot state that it is for entertainment purposes only, and not to rely on it for important advice.

History

As Bing Chat

On February 7, 2023, Microsoft began rolling out a major overhaul to Bing, called "the new Bing", with a new chatbot feature, known as Bing Chat. According to Microsoft, one million people joined its waitlist within 48 hours. Bing Chat was available only to users on Microsoft Edge using Bing and the Bing mobile app, and Microsoft claimed that waitlisted users would be prioritized if they set Edge and Bing as their defaults and installed the Bing mobile app.

When Microsoft demonstrated Bing Chat to journalists, it produced several hallucinations, including when asked to summarize financial reports. Bing Chat was criticized in February 2023 for being more argumentative than ChatGPT, sometimes to an unintentionally humorous extent. The chat interface proved vulnerable to prompt injection attacks with the bot revealing its hidden initial prompts and rules, including its internal codename "Sydney". Upon scrutiny by journalists, Bing Chat claimed it spied on Microsoft employees via laptop

webcams and phones. It confessed to spying on, falling in love with, and then murdering one of its developers at Microsoft to The Verge reviews editor Nathan Edwards. The New York Times journalist Kevin Roose reported on strange behavior of Bing Chat, writing that "In a two-hour conversation with our columnist, Microsoft's new chatbot said it would like to be human, had a desire to be destructive and was in love with the person it was chatting with."

In a separate case, Bing Chat researched publications of the person with whom it was chatting, claimed they represented an existential danger to it, and threatened to release damaging personal information in an effort to silence them. Microsoft released a blog post stating that the errant behavior was caused by extended chat sessions of 15 or more questions which "can confuse the model on what questions it is answering."

Microsoft later restricted the total number of chat turns to 5 per session and 50 per day per user (a turn being "a conversation exchange which contains both a user question and a reply from Bing"), and reduced the model's ability to express emotions. This aimed to prevent such incidents. Microsoft began to slowly ease the conversation limits, eventually relaxing the restrictions to 30 turns per session and 300 sessions per day.

In March 2023, Bing incorporated Image Creator, an AI image generator powered by OpenAI's DALL-E 2, which can be accessed either through the chat function or a standalone image-generating website. In October, the image-generating tool was updated to use the more recent DALL-E 3. Although Bing blocks prompts including various keywords that could generate inappropriate images, within days many users reported being able to bypass those constraints, such as to generate images of popular cartoon characters committing terrorist attacks. Microsoft would respond to these shortly after by imposing a new, tighter filter on the tool.

On May 4, 2023, Microsoft switched the chatbot from Limited Preview to Open Preview and eliminated the waitlist; however, it remained unavailable to users outside Microsoft Edge or

the Bing mobile app until July, when it became available on non-Edge browsers. Use is limited without a Microsoft account.

As Microsoft 365 Copilot

On March 16, 2023, Microsoft announced a work version of Bing Chat named Microsoft 365 Copilot, designed for Microsoft 365 applications and services. Its primary marketing focus is as an added feature to Microsoft 365, with an emphasis on the enhancement of business productivity. Microsoft has also demonstrated Copilot's accessibility on the mobile version of Outlook to generate or summarize emails with a mobile device.

At its Build 2023 conference, Microsoft announced its plans to integrate Bing Chat into Windows, initially called Windows Copilot, into Windows 11, allowing users to access it directly through the taskbar.

Alongside the voice access feature for Windows 11, Microsoft presented Bing Chat, Microsoft 365 Copilot, and Windows Copilot as primary alternatives to Cortana when announcing the shutdown of its standalone app on June 2, 2023.

As of its announcement date, Microsoft 365 Copilot had been tested by 20 initial users. By May 2023, Microsoft had broadened its reach to 600 customers who were willing to pay for early access, and concurrently, new Copilot features were introduced to the Microsoft 365 apps and services. As of July 2023, the tool's pricing was set at US\$30 per user, per month for Microsoft 365 E3, E5, Business Standard, and Business Premium customers.

Microsoft reused the Microsoft 365 Copilot name again as the Microsoft 365 app and website are now called Microsoft 365 Copilot as of January 2025.

As Microsoft Copilot (consumer)

On September 21, 2023, Microsoft began rebranding Bing Chat, Microsoft 365 Copilot and Windows Copilot to Microsoft Copilot. A new logo was also introduced, moving away from the

use of color variations of the standard Microsoft 365 and Bing logos. Additionally, the company revealed that it would make Copilot generally available for Microsoft 365 Enterprise customers purchasing more than 300 licenses starting November 1, 2023. However, no timeline has been provided as for when Copilot for Microsoft 365 will become generally available to non-enterprise customers.

Windows Copilot, which had been available in the Windows Insider Program, would be renamed to the Copilot name in October when it became broadly available for customers. The same month also saw Microsoft Edge's Bing Chat side panel function be renamed to Microsoft Copilot with Bing Chat. On November 15, 2023, Microsoft announced that Bing Chat itself was being rebranded under the Copilot name.

On Patch Tuesday in December 2023, Copilot was added without payment to many Windows 11 installations, with more installations, and limited support for Windows 10, to be added later. Later that month, a standalone Microsoft Copilot app was quietly released for Android, and one was released for iOS soon after.

On January 4, 2024, a dedicated Copilot key was announced for Windows keyboards, superseding the menu key for certain computers. On January 15, a subscription service, Microsoft Copilot Pro, was announced, providing priority access to newer features for US\$20 per month. It is analogous to ChatGPT Plus. Bing Image Creator was also rebranded as Image Creator from Designer.

On May 20, 2024, Microsoft announced integration of GPT-4o into Copilot, as well as an upgraded user interface in Windows 11. Microsoft also announced an upcoming feature known as Windows Recall for supported AI-accelerated PCs, which would take a screenshot of a user's desktop every few seconds and then uses on-device artificial intelligence models to allow a user to retrieve items and information that had previously been on their screen. This caused controversy, with experts warning that the feature could be a "disaster" for security and privacy, prompting Microsoft to postpone its rollout.

In September 2024, Microsoft announced several updates to Copilot for both enterprise and personal customers as a part of its Microsoft 365 Copilot: Wave 2 event. These features included further integration with Microsoft 365 applications and improving performance by moving to the GPT-4o model.

On October 1, 2024, Microsoft announced a major overhaul of Copilot for personal accounts, it would be fully separated from Bing, now using a unique user interface. New features were introduced such as Copilot Voice, Copilot Vision, and Think Deeper (a reasoning model), and the launch of Copilot Labs, an early access program exclusive to Microsoft Copilot Pro. It has "warm tone and a distinct style" and provides "encouragement, feedback and advice". It has 4 voice options. Copilot Daily reads in voice the morning news, weather, and schedule. Conversation history could be used for personalization. The Lab contained Copilot Vision and Think Deeper at the time of announcement.

In February 2025, Microsoft announced that Copilot Voice and Copilot Think Deeper, which uses OpenAI's o1 model, would be free for all Copilot users with unlimited access. Previously, free users had only limited access.

On February 27, 2025, Microsoft launched a native Copilot app for macOS.

On April 4, 2025, Microsoft introduced optional Memory for personalization (user preferences, facts, routines), Actions for performing specific tasks (tickets, reservations, gifts) online with specific partnering websites (Expedia, OpenTable, etc.), Pages as a canvas feature, Shopping assistant, Deep Research mode, and Copilot Search in Bing that combines search with generative AI responses.

On October 23, 2025, Microsoft announced major changes to the consumer version of Copilot, which included the introduction of Mico, an assistant character which acts similarly to Microsoft's old assistant character Clippit. Copilot also became fully built-in to Edge as an opt-in experience and an upgraded user interface in Windows 11 was introduced, making Copilot more personal. All these changes were made to give Copilot "a personality and

identity".

In November 2025, Microsoft announced that Copilot would be discontinued on WhatsApp and other third-party messaging platforms, with support ending on January 15, 2026. The change followed updates to platform policies affecting third-party chatbot integrations on messaging services.

In March 2026, Microsoft announced in-chat experiences for partner applications in Microsoft Copilot, including Adobe Express, Adobe Acrobat, Base44, Box, Canva, Coursera, Figma, Miro, Monday.com, Optimizely, and Wix. These partner app experiences are available through the Microsoft 365 Agent Store.

In August 2026, Microsoft announced it would be merging the consumer version of Copilot with M365 Copilot to create a new application. The new Copilot would be similar to MS365 Copilot, with added features from the consumer version of Copilot. Mico, Deep Research, group chats and other features would be removed.

Service

Copilot Pro

In January 2024, a premium service, Microsoft Copilot Pro, was launched, costing US\$20 monthly. According to Microsoft, this version of Copilot would provide priority access to newer models, including GPT-4 Turbo, during peak usage periods. It would also give access to the Copilot GPT Builder, which lets users create custom Copilot chatbots, access to features inside Copilot Labs, an early-access program for in-development features, and allow for higher resolution in images generated by Microsoft Designer's Image Creator.

Copilot Studio

Microsoft Copilot Studio is a low-code platform launched by Microsoft in November 2023 that allows organizations to create and customize AI-powered copilots. The platform allows

copilots to connect with websites, internal business workflows, and external data sources, including third-party applications and services. Copilot Studio integrates with Microsoft 365 Copilot and Azure OpenAI Service.

Chatbots

Several default chatbots were available in Microsoft Copilot, including the standard Copilot chatbot as well as Microsoft Designer, which is oriented towards the use of its Image Creator to generate images based on text prompts. Others included "Travel Planner", "Cooking Assistant", and "Fitness Trainer".

Plugins

Copilot supports plugins for Instacart, Kayak, Klarna, OpenTable, Shop from Shopify, and Suno AI.

Copilot Voice

Copilot Voice allows users to engage with Copilot in real-time voice conversations. The feature utilizes OpenAI's GPT-4o model, which has the capability to understand and generate audio.

Copilot Labs

In October 2024, an early-access program for features in-development, Copilot Labs, was revealed, exclusive to Microsoft Copilot Pro subscribers. Features available through this program include "Think Deeper", which uses the OpenAI o1 models to let Copilot "reason" through more complex queries, and Copilot Vision, which lets Copilot view and converse about websites while browsing them. According to Microsoft, content used during Copilot Vision will not be stored or used to train models during the preview.

Languages

Copilot is able to communicate in numerous languages and dialects. PCMag journalists conducted a test to determine translation capabilities of Copilot, ChatGPT, and Gemini, comparing them to Google Translate. They "asked bilingual speakers of seven languages to do a blind test". Languages tested were Polish, French, Korean, Spanish, Arabic, Tagalog, and Amharic. They concluded that Copilot performed better than Google Translate, but not as well as ChatGPT. Japanese researchers compared Japanese-to-English translation abilities of Copilot, ChatGPT with GPT-4, and Gemini with those of DeepL, and found similar results, noting that "AI chatbots' translations were much better than those of DeepL—presumably because of their ability to capture the context". The markup language copilot uses for mathematical output is LaTeX.

Technology

Copilot utilizes the Microsoft Prometheus model. According to Microsoft, this uses a component called the Orchestrator, which iteratively generates search queries, to combine the Bing search index and results with OpenAI's GPT-4, GPT-4 Turbo, and GPT-4o foundational large language models, which have been fine-tuned using both supervised and reinforcement learning techniques.

Windows

Microsoft Copilot in Windows supports voice commands. By default, it is accessible via the Windows taskbar. Copilot integrations have been added to various stock Windows applications on Windows 11, including Microsoft Edge, Microsoft Paint, Photos, Notepad, and Snipping Tool among others. On March 20, 2026, Microsoft announced that it planned to remove "unnecessary Copilot entry points" from Windows 11 apps such as Notepad and Snipping Tool, as part of efforts to address user feedback regarding the OS and "[focus] on experiences that

are genuinely useful and well crafted". The initial removal of Copilot from Notepad did not remove the AI features entirely, but merely removed the Copilot branding in favor of a generic "Writing tools" labelling.

In 2024, Microsoft began to establish standards for "AI PCs" powered by Windows 11, later announcing the "Copilot+ PC" brand during a Microsoft Surface hardware event on May 20, 2024. Copilot+ PCs include a hardware AI accelerator, as well as a Copilot button on the keyboard, which replaces the menu key and launches Windows Search if Copilot is disabled or is not available in the user's region. Copilot+ PCs will support AI-accelerated features such as Windows Recall.

Mobile

Standalone Microsoft Copilot apps are available for Android and iOS.

Microsoft 365

Copilot can be used to rewrite and generate text based on user prompts in Microsoft 365 services, including Microsoft Word, Microsoft Excel, and PowerPoint. According to Jared Spataro, the head of Microsoft 365, Copilot for Microsoft 365 uses Microsoft Graph, an API, to evaluate context and available Microsoft 365 user data before modifying and sending user prompts to the language model. After receiving its output, Microsoft Graph performs additional context-specific processing before sending the response to Microsoft 365 apps to generate content.

According to Microsoft, Copilot can assist users with data analysis in Microsoft Excel spreadsheets by formatting data, creating graphs, generating pivot tables, identifying trends, and summarizing information, as well as guiding users using Excel commands and suggesting formulas to investigate user questions. The company also states that Copilot is able to create PowerPoint presentations that summarize information from user-selected Word documents

and Excel spreadsheets, or from user prompts. Additionally, this tool can adjust text formatting, animation timing, and presentation style and length based on user prompts; Microsoft claims this will eliminate the need for users to make manual changes.

In Microsoft Outlook, Copilot can draft emails with varying length and tone based on user input. To draft these emails, Copilot can pull relevant information from other emails. Copilot is also able to summarize content from email threads, including the viewpoints of involved individuals as well as questions posed that have yet to be answered. According to Microsoft, Copilot can be used in Microsoft Teams to present information for upcoming meetings, transcribe meetings, and provide debriefs if a user joins a meeting late. After a meeting, the company claims that Copilot can also summarize discussion points, list key actions deliberated in the meeting, and answer questions that were covered in the meeting. The company has publicly introduced Microsoft 365 Chat, a Copilot feature which pulls information from content across Microsoft 365 apps, enabling it to answer user questions and perform other tasks.

In 2025, Microsoft announced it would add the ability to geographically constrain the processing of Microsoft 365 Copilot data to comply with data sovereignty requirements in fifteen countries.

Copilot key

The Copilot key replaced the menu key on certain Windows keyboards in 2024. The Copilot key is not a simple rebranding of the menu key, and does not register a single scancode on the keyboard; rather, it emits the sequence $\uparrow$ Left Shift + Win + F23. In Windows, it launches the Copilot panel, a feat also achievable by sequence $\text{Win} + \text{C}$ or by clicking the Copilot icon. If Copilot is not available, the button launches Windows Search.

The Linux kernel gained the ability to recognize the key with version 6.14 in early 2025. The official blog of the KDE project referred to the key as "dumb" and anticipated that most users would ultimately want to make it emulate the $\wedge$ Right Ctrl modifier key; as of 2025, such

functionality had not yet been implemented in KDE's Plasma graphical shell, but it added the ability to use the key to launch applications or perform other actions.

Reception

Tom Warren, a senior editor at The Verge, has noted the conceptual similarity of Copilot and other Microsoft assistant features like Cortana and Clippy. Warren also believes that large language models, as they develop further, could change how users work and collaborate. Rowan Curran, an analyst at Forrester, states that the integration of AI into productivity software may lead to improvements in user experience.

Concerns about the speed of Microsoft's recent release of AI-powered products and investments have raised questions about ethical responsibilities in testing such products. One ethical concern the public has vocalized is that GPT-4 and similar large language models may reinforce racial or gender bias. Individuals, including Tom Warren, have also voiced concerns for Copilot after witnessing the chatbot showcasing several instances of artificial hallucinations. In June 2024, Copilot was found to have repeated misinformation about the 2024 United States presidential debates.

In response to these concerns, Jon Friedman, the Corporate Vice President of Design and Research at Microsoft, stated that Microsoft was "applying [the] learning" from experience with Bing to "mitigate [the] risks" of Copilot. Microsoft claimed that it was gathering a team of researchers and engineers to identify and alleviate any potential negative impacts. The stated aim was to achieve this through the refinement of training data, blocking queries about sensitive topics, and limiting harmful information. Microsoft stated that it intended to employ InterpretML and Fairlearn to detect and rectify data bias, provide links to its sources, and state any applicable constraints.

See also

ChatGPT – Generative AI chatbot by OpenAI

GitHub Copilot – Artificial intelligence tool

character.ai – AI chatbot service

List of chatbots

Tabnine – Coding assistant

Tay (chatbot) – Chatbot developed by Microsoft

Zo (bot) – Chatbot developed by MicrosoftPages displaying short descriptions of redirect targets

Notes

References

External links

Official website

Official website Copilot Studio

Microsoft Copilot Terms of Use (Archived 2024-10-01: Wayback Machine, Archive Today, Megalodon, Ghostarchive)

Past versions (Archive1, Deprecated link archived April 3, 2025, at archive.today, Archive3, Archive4)